

Photograph by VENKAT BALAJI



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amidst a lily pond. The moment you step in, the lilies and the swimming fish welcome you and the floorplate ebbs and flows to accommodate all functions without leaving their side. The material palette is deliberately all natural, consisting primarily of stone and wood. Salim is quick to add that "It's not just about the visual experience, a truly calming space is one that allows nature to be experienced with multiple senses and that's what we try to create. The sound of water gushing in the pond. The rugged texture of natural stone, wood or earth touching your feet when you walk barefoot in your home," he says, adding, "The smell of earth after the first rains when you're drinking your evening coffee in the verandah. The view of trees changing colours as the seasons pass, a view of the mountains surrounding your home from your study table. When all your senses can feel the presence of nature around, that's when you can truly unwind."

Architect Naomy Parikh's years learning pottery in Auroville, near Puducherry, gave her a first-hand experience of living with nature. "It's a completely different way of life. Not just in terms of aesthetics or architecture, but in that it's sort of a barefoot life, lived more outdoors than indoors." Her experience as an architect and potter has fostered a deep interest in material inquiry and community engagement, shaping the ethos of her Ahmedabad-based practice, Doro. When she was approached by a ceramic artist to design her home in Auroville, it became important to recreate the barefoot way of living. "It was a very tight 30 by 50 feet plot with six existing trees. We made the conscious effort of not designing a single large forecourt or backyard, but rather having every space open onto its own courtyard. This way every space breathes at all times. In this house, there are more semi-open spaces from which you transition outdoors than spaces that are completely indoors, which responds very specifically to the homeowner's idea of a comfortable life. If you had to imagine a house like this in Ahmedabad, you'd probably say it's not very functional. But in terms of how this artist wanted to live, it absolutely is. Comfort is extremely contextual," says Parikh about the Saag Residence. A material palette of lime, mud plaster, terracotta, granite and IPS, rich with their own textures, reinforces the connection with nature.

CALMING THRESHOLDS
(clockwise from far left) The Staircourt House by R C Architects crafts an indoor oases shielded from urban life; Doro celebrates barefoot living at Saag, a ceramicist's home in Auroville; another picture from the same home

The ideas of being one with nature and crafting a calming experience through transition spaces also find resonance in the work of Origin Architects, co-founded by architects Apeksha Kute and Nitin Kute in Nashik. The city is home to around 24 dam reservoirs and is surrounded by the Sahyadri mountain range. This scenic landscape is especially conducive to hospitality developments like resorts and rental villas. Designed by Origin Architects, the farmhouse overlook-